PHISHING AWARENESS

PROTECT YOURSELF ONLINE

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WHAT IS PHISHING?

Phishing is a type of cyber attack where criminals pretend to be trusted sources to trick you into sharing sensitive information. They send fake emails, messages, or create fake websites that look real. Their goal is to steal your passwords, credit card numbers, or personal data. Think of it like a digital con artist wearing a disguise to gain your trust and steal your information.



COMMON TYPES OF PHISHING ATTACKS

Phishing attacks come in many forms, each designed to trick you in different ways. Understanding these common types will help you recognize and avoid them. Here are the three most prevalent phishing methods you're likely to encounter in your daily life.

Email Phishing
The most common type. Attackers send fake emails pretending to be trusted companies like banks, Amazon, or Netflix. These emails often create urgency, asking you to "verify your account" or "update payment info" through malicious links.

Spear Phishing
A targeted attack aimed at specific individuals. Attackers research their victims using social media and company websites to craft personalized messages. These are harder to detect because they reference real details about you or your workplace.

Smishing (SMS Phishing)
Phishing via text messages. You might receive texts claiming to be from delivery services, banks, or government agencies with urgent requests to click links. These often include shortened URLs to hide malicious destinations.



REAL-WORLD PHISHING EXAMPLES

Example 1: Fake Bank Alert

"Your account has been compromised! Click here immediately to verify your identity."

Red Flags:

- Urgent, threatening language
- Generic greeting (no name)
- Suspicious sender address
- Pressure to act immediately

Example 2: Package Delivery Scam

"Your package could not be delivered. Pay $1.99 to reschedule."

Red Flags:

- Unexpected delivery notice
- Request for payment via link
- Misspelled company name

HOW TO SPOT FAKE WEBSITES

Red Flags to Watch For:

- Check the URL carefully - look for misspellings like "amaz0n.com" or "paypa1.com"
- Missing padlock icon or "https://" in the address bar means the site isn't secure
- Poor design quality, broken images, and spelling errors throughout the page
- Urgent pop-ups demanding immediate action or personal information
- Contact information that's missing, fake, or leads nowhere



SOCIAL ENGINEERING TACTICS

Urgency

"Act now or lose access!" Attackers create time pressure to make you act without thinking. They want you to panic and skip verification steps.

Authority

Impersonating your boss, IT department, or government agencies. They use official-sounding titles to make requests seem legitimate.

Fear

"Your account will be suspended!" Threats of negative consequences trigger emotional responses that override logical thinking.

Trust

Building rapport or pretending to be someone you know. They exploit relationships and familiarity to lower your defenses.

HOW TO PROTECT YOURSELF FROM PHISHING

Staying safe from phishing attacks doesn't require technical expertise. By following a few simple habits, you can significantly reduce your risk of falling victim to these scams. Here are three essential practices that everyone should adopt to protect their personal and professional information online.

Verify Sender Identity

Always check the sender's email address carefully. Look for misspellings or unusual domains. When in doubt, contact the organization directly using official contact information from their website, not from the suspicious message.

Never Click Suspicious Links

Hover over links before clicking to preview the actual URL. If an email creates urgency or seems too good to be true, don't click. Instead, navigate directly to the website by typing the address in your browser.

Enable Multi-Factor Authentication

Add an extra layer of security to all your accounts. Even if attackers steal your password through phishing, MFA prevents them from accessing your account without the second verification step.

QUIZ

CAN YOU SPOT THE PHISHING ATTEMPT?

You receive an email: "URGENT: Your account will be suspended in 24 hours! Click here immediately to verify your identity: www.amaz0n-security-verify.com" The sender is support@amaz0n-alerts.net. What red flags do you see? (Think about: urgency, spelling, domain name, sender address)

QUIZ #2

TRUE OR FALSE: A LINK IS SAFE IF IT LOOKS CORRECT?

Statement: "If a link displays 'www.yourbank.com' in the email text, it's safe to click."
Answer: FALSE! Attackers can display any text while hiding a malicious URL underneath. Always hover over links to see the actual destination before clicking. The displayed text and real link can be completely different!

STAY ALERT, STAY SAFE!



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